

# Conflict in the Middle East, 1945–1995

## High-Yield Revision Cheat Sheet

### 1. The British Withdrawal and the Creation of Israel (1945–1948)

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- The British Mandate, formalized in 1923, faced a conflicting 'dual obligation' to establish a Jewish national home while protecting Arab civil and political rights.
- Zionist insurgent groups (Haganah, Irgun, Lehi) used violence to force British withdrawal and bypass immigration limits.
- On 22 July 1946, the Irgun bombed the British administrative headquarters at the King David Hotel, causing 91 deaths and pushing Britain to refer Palestine to the UN.
- UN Resolution 181 (November 1947) proposed partitioning Palestine into a Jewish state (55% of land) and an Arab state (45% of land), with Jerusalem under international control.
- Zionist leaders accepted the UN Partition Plan as a path to statehood, while Arab leaders completely rejected it as an unjust seizure of Arab-majority land.
- The British Mandate expired on 14 May 1948; David Ben-Gurion declared the creation of the State of Israel.
- On 15 May 1948, forces from five Arab nations (Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq) invaded, sparking the first Arab-Israeli War.

## 2. The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War and State Consolidation (1949–1954)

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- The 1949 Armistice Agreements established the 'Green Line' borders, expanding Israel's territory to 79% of Palestine (24% more than the UN Partition Plan).
- Transjordan took control of and annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem, while Egypt occupied the Gaza Strip.
- Over 700,000 Palestinians fled or were expelled from their homes, creating a massive refugee crisis known as al-Nakba (the Catastrophe).
- The UN established the United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA) in December 1949 to provide temporary camps and humanitarian aid to displaced Palestinians.
- In May 1948, Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion created the unified Israeli Defence Forces (IDF), merging and dissolving pre-state paramilitary groups like the Haganah and Irgun.
- The Knesset passed the Law of Return in July 1950, granting any Jewish person worldwide the right to immigrate to Israel and receive automatic citizenship.
- Israel consolidated its economy and infrastructure through massive financial aid from the United States and reparations agreements with West Germany.

### 3. Suez Crisis and Rise of Nasser (1955–1963)

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- Colonel Gamal Abdel Nasser became President of Egypt in 1954, championing Pan-Arab nationalism and taking a hard stance against Israel.
- In February 1955, the IDF launched a massive raid on Egyptian Army Headquarters in Gaza, killing 38 Egyptian soldiers and prompting Nasser to seek Soviet arms.
- Nasser signed the Czech Arms Deal in September 1955 to buy advanced Soviet aircraft and tanks, which severely alarmed Israel, Britain, and the USA.
- In response to the US and UK withdrawing financial funding for the Aswan High Dam, Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal on 26 July 1956.
- In October 1956, Britain, France, and Israel signed the secret Protocol of Sèvres, planning a coordinated invasion of Egypt.
- On 29 October 1956, Israel invaded the Sinai Peninsula, and British and French troops subsequently landed at Port Said to seize the canal.
- Massive economic and diplomatic pressure from the USA (President Eisenhower) and the USSR forced a tripartite withdrawal, leaving Nasser as a Pan-Arab hero.
- The UN deployed its first Emergency Force (UNEF) in 1957 as a border buffer zone, halting Gaza-based Fedayeen raids and reopening the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping.

## 4. The Outbreak of the Six Day War (1964–1967)

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- The Arab League held the Cairo Conference in January 1964, resulting in the creation of the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) and Fatah, led by Yasser Arafat.
- Border skirmishes escalated over the Headwater Diversion Plan, as Arab states attempted to divert River Jordan tributaries to starve Israel of water.
- In November 1966, an Israeli reprisal raid on the West Bank village of Samu killed 15 Jordanian soldiers, triggering violent anti-government protests in Jordan.
- On 7 April 1967, border clashes between Israel and Syria led to an aerial dogfight in which the Israeli air force shot down six Syrian MiG-21 fighters over Damascus.
- On 13 May 1967, the USSR provided Egypt with a false intelligence report claiming Israel was massing ten brigades on the Syrian border for an imminent invasion.
- To support Syria, Nasser mobilized Egypt's army into the Sinai, demanded the withdrawal of UNEF peacekeepers, and closed the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping.
- On 30 May 1967, Nasser signed a mutual defense pact with Jordan, placing the Jordanian army under Egyptian command and effectively surrounding Israel.

## 5. The Six Day War and its Aftermath (1967–1972)

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- Believing an invasion was imminent, Israel launched a pre-emptive strike on 5 June 1967 (Operation Focus), destroying 90% of the Egyptian air force on the runways.
- Within six days, the IDF won a decisive victory, capturing the Sinai Peninsula and Gaza Strip from Egypt, the West Bank and East Jerusalem from Jordan, and the Golan Heights from Syria.
- The war displaced over 300,000 more Palestinians and brought over a million Palestinians in the West Bank and Gaza under Israeli military occupation.
- In November 1967, the UN Security Council passed Resolution 242, establishing the 'land for peace' formula, which was rejected or stalled by translation discrepancies.
- In August 1967, Arab League leaders met at the Khartoum Summit and issued the 'Three Nos': no peace with Israel, no recognition of Israel, and no negotiations with Israel.
- Palestinian groups shifted to international terrorism; the PFLP executed the Dawson's Field plane hijackings in September 1970, blowing up three commercial aircraft.
- The Dawson's Field crisis prompted King Hussein to launch the bloody 'Black September' civil war, which crushed and expelled PLO militias from Jordan to Lebanon.
- In September 1972, the Black September splinter group murdered 11 Israeli athletes at the Munich Olympics, provoking Israel's global 'Operation Wrath of God' retaliations.

## 6. The Yom Kippur War and the Oil Weapon (1973)

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- Anwar Sadat succeeded Nasser as President of Egypt in 1970, aiming to break the diplomatic stalemate ('no peace, no war') and reclaim the lost Sinai Peninsula.
- On 6 October 1973, on the Jewish holy day of Yom Kippur, Egypt and Syria launched a coordinated surprise attack, overrunning the Bar Lev Line and Golan Heights.
- Israel suffered severe initial casualties and lost substantial armor and aircraft before mobilizing its military reserves.
- Superpowers intervened heavily: the USA provided Israel with a vital military airlift (Operation Nickel Grass), while the USSR supplied Egypt and Syria with advanced weaponry.
- The IDF successfully counter-attacked, crossing the Suez Canal to encircle Egypt's Third Army, which prompted Soviet threats of direct intervention.
- Arab members of OPEC deployed the 'oil weapon,' placing a total embargo on Western nations supporting Israel, which quadrupled crude prices and triggered a global energy crisis.
- The USA and USSR co-sponsored UN Resolution 338, enforcing a ceasefire on 25 October 1973, leaving both sides in a costly stalemate.

## 7. Diplomatic Negotiations and Peace with Egypt (1973–1979)

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- The OPEC oil crisis forced the United States to actively intervene as a mediator to prevent future oil embargos and limit Soviet regional influence.
- US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger initiated 'shuttle diplomacy' (1974–75), brokering disengagement agreements that pushed back Israeli troops and reopened the Suez Canal in June 1975.
- In November 1977, Anwar Sadat made a historic visit to Jerusalem to address the Israeli Knesset, breaking the Arab taboo by offering recognition in exchange for Sinai.
- In September 1978, US President Jimmy Carter hosted Sadat and Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin for thirteen days of secret negotiations at Camp David.
- The Camp David Accords established a framework for an Egyptian-Israeli peace treaty and vague guidelines for Palestinian self-rule in the occupied territories.
- On 26 March 1979, Sadat and Begin signed the formal Treaty of Washington, making Egypt the first Arab nation to officially recognize the State of Israel.
- As a consequence of the treaty, Egypt regained the Sinai Peninsula, but was expelled from the Arab League, and Sadat was assassinated by Islamic extremists in 1981.

## 8. The PLO, Lebanon, and the First Intifada (1970–1993)

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- Following their expulsion from Jordan in 1970, the PLO established its central headquarters and armed bases in Beirut and southern Lebanon ('Fatahland').
- In March 1978, Fatah militants launched the Coastal Road Massacre, killing 37 Israeli civilians and prompting Israel's limited invasion of southern Lebanon (Operation Litani).
- On 6 June 1982, following the attempted assassination of Ambassador Shlomo Argov, Israel launched 'Operation Peace for Galilee,' a full-scale invasion of Lebanon.
- Israeli forces besieged West Beirut for two months, eventually forcing Yasser Arafat and 14,000 PLO fighters to evacuate by sea to Tunis, Tunisia.
- In September 1982, Lebanese Christian Phalangist militias entered the Sabra and Shatila refugee camps and massacred hundreds of unarmed Palestinian civilians.
- The First Palestinian Intifada erupted spontaneously in the Gaza Strip on 8 December 1987, characterized by mass strikes, boycotts, and youth throwing stones at the IDF.
- Defense Minister Yitzhak Rabin ordered a harsh military 'Iron Fist' policy to crush the uprising, which drew widespread international condemnation.
- The Intifada saw the rise of the radical Islamic group Hamas, which challenged the secular leadership of the PLO.



## 9. The Oslo Accords and the Peace Process (1988–1995)

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- In December 1988, Yasser Arafat addressed the UN in Geneva, officially renouncing terrorism, accepting UN Resolutions 242 and 338, and recognizing Israel.
- The collapse of the Soviet Union in December 1991 deprived the PLO of its primary financial and military backing, severely weakening its negotiating position.
- During the 1991 Gulf War, Arafat publicly supported Saddam Hussein's invasion of Kuwait, resulting in the PLO's diplomatic isolation and loss of funding from Gulf states.
- The election of Yitzhak Rabin's moderate Labor government in 1992 opened a window of opportunity, leading to secret back-channel negotiations in Oslo, Norway.
- The Oslo I Accords (September 1993) established formal mutual recognition between Israel and the PLO, and created the Palestinian National Authority (PNA).
- Under Oslo I, the IDF began a phased military withdrawal from the Gaza Strip and the West Bank town of Jericho, transferring civil administration to the PNA under Arafat.
- The Oslo II Accord (September 1995) divided the West Bank into Areas A (PNA control), B (PNA civil, joint security), and C (complete Israeli civil and military control).
- The peace process faced violent opposition from Hamas suicide bombings and right-wing Israeli settlers, culminating in the assassination of Rabin by Yigal Amir on 4 November 1995.